CDE2501 SUSTAINABLE SYSTEMS FOR LIVEABLE CITIES

SITE GUIDE FOR

CHINATOWN

AY 2025 – 2026 SEMESTER 2

Introduction to Site Guides

Welcome to Liveable Cities! Each of your teams will be working on a site from the following choices – Jurong, Woodlands, Punggol, Bras Basah - Bugis, Chinatown, Tampines and Queenstown.

To help you better navigate your site, we have created site guides to serve as starter packs to help you dive into your projects as quickly as possible.

We provide the following information for each site guide:

1. Maps marking the suggested boundaries of the sites
2. Prompts that spotlight key issues which you can apply to develop your project
3. A list of references to assist with your research

While we welcome you to use the prompts, you do not need to strictly adhere to them. Feel free to combine ideas from the prompts and/or explore other urban issues you are passionate about.

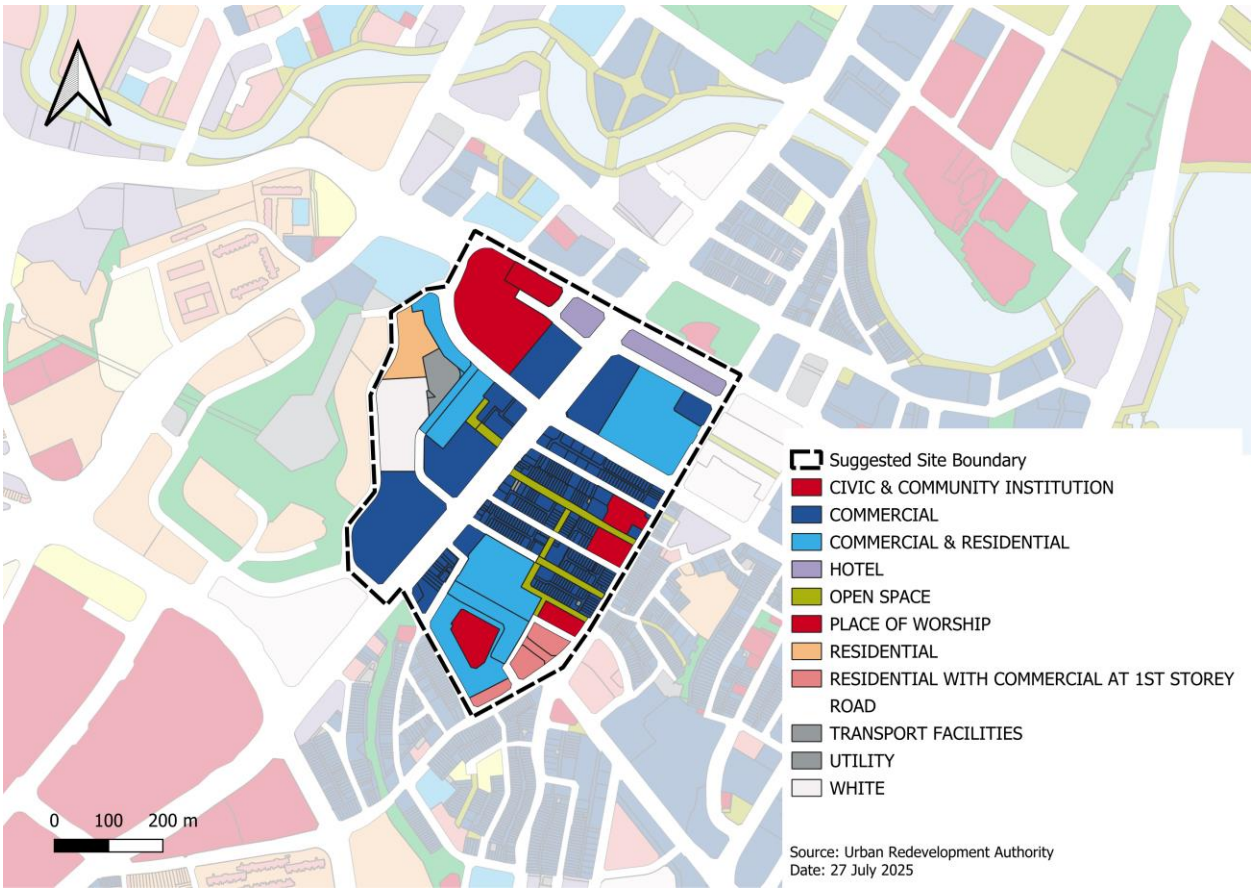
Note: As you learn more about the site and discover what interests the team most, you can also choose to focus on a section of the site and/or extend the site boundaries a little to areas relevant to the issue you are studying.

Chinatown

This site contains the following landmarks:

- Transport nodes e.g. Chinatown MRT, Maxwell MRT
- Religious sites e.g Masjid Jamae (Chulia), Sri Mariamman Temple, Buddha Tooth Relic Temple & Museum
- Retail e.g. People's Park Centre, People's Park Complex, Chinatown Complex , Chinatown Point, Hong Lim Complex , OG Building
- Community and recreation spaces e.g. Kreta Ayer Community Club
- Civic and community institutions e.g. Family Justice Courts, State Courts

You can also consider exploring other potential areas in this site as well.



Prompts

- How has the evolving landscape of Chinatown impacted the cultural identity of Chinatown?
- Does Singapore continue to maintain a high quality of life and sustain businesses in older HDB complexes and shophouses like Chinatown? Are current measures enough? What more can be done?
- How can heritage precincts evolve to remain attractive and appeal to visitors / consumers today?
- How can Singapore improve the vehicular and pedestrian experience in heritage precincts?

Starter References

As you read the following references, think about:

- What are the intentions that URA and other government agencies have for Chinatown?
- What are the strategies or interventions they are planning to make to achieve these intentions?
- Are these strategies or interventions sufficient to achieve these intentions?
- In the first place, are these intentions good for Chinatown in helping it to achieve High Quality of Life, Sustainable Environment and Competitive Economy?

URA's Draft Master Plan 2025 for Central Area with potential developments that may directly and indirectly impact Chinatown: Central Area | URA Master Plan

Chinatown is an ethnic enclave in Singapore known for its rich cultural history and heritage. In recent years, the area has undergone significant changes due to urban redevelopment and gentrification. As such, there has been increasing debates on how Singapore should best balance cultural preservation and modernisation. The following links detail these debates:

The Straits Times article about Chinatowns across Asia (including Singapore): The changing face of Chinatowns across Asia | The Straits Times

Channel NewsAsia (CNA) article about gentrification in historical districts in Singapore: Heritage and gentrification: Is there a win-win for neighbourhoods? - CNA

Channel NewsAsia (CNA) article about historical conservation efforts in Chinatown: Smith Street revamp: Chinatown businesses look to preserve culture, experts warn against gentrification - CNA

As Chinatown continues to modernise and grow, there has been an increasing number of Chinese retailers that have set up shop next to long-term Chinatown businesses who have been in the area for decades. The following links investigate the impacts of this phenomenon on Chinatown's cultural identity:

The Straits Times article about how Chinatown merchants are modernising their businesses to stay relevant: Innovation amid tradition: How Chinatown merchants move with the times | The Straits Times

The RICE Media video about the increasing number of Chinese brands in Singapore and its impact on the local F&B landscape: Mixue, Luckin, Scarlett: Too Fast, Too Many, Too Soon? | Singapore, Unfiltered - YouTube